embassy in Beijing noted, India “was more than present”—the result of Nehru sending Krishna Menon to Geneva.[55]

The conference did not alleviate Nehru’s doubts about the US approach. Unlike Dulles, the prime minister did not think the participating Chinese premier was “uncompromising” or merely following Moscow’s lead at the conference. He believed that any rigidity on Zhou’s part stemmed from American behavior—a sense exacerbated by Zhou’s assertion to Nehru that the US attitude basically was “to obstruct any settlement in the Conference.”[56]

Nehru thought the options in Southeast Asia were clear: (1) a settlement that accepted and stabilized the status quo and essentially prevented Chinese expansion, or (2) a lack of agreement, which meant continuation of military activity that would benefit China and the Vietminh. He was concerned that US policy was leading to the latter, which, in turn, would eventually lead to war.[57] Seeking a settlement, Nehru proposed a peace plan in conjunction with other Asian leaders and sought British support for it. Furthermore, egged on by British foreign secretary Anthony Eden, Nehru urged Zhou to cease large-scale attacks in Indochina, even getting the Chinese premier’s public endorsement in principle of noninterference in Southeast Asia.[58]

Nehru had not expected much to come from the Geneva conference but was relatively pleased with the result.[59] Krishna Menon’s shuttle diplomacy facilitated the achievement of a settlement. India subsequently agreed to chair the International Control Commission, created to supervise ceasefires in Indochina. The US, on the other hand, refused to sign the agreement. It had been pleased neither with the settlement nor with Krishna Menon’s shuttling.

The US-India differences on Indochina only added to negative American perceptions of India’s role in Asia. An unnamed US policymaker lamented publicly that “the Chinese Communists in a sense hold a veto over India.”[60] During congressional hearings on the foreign assistance program, members of the House Foreign Affairs Committee questioned India’s attitude. Representative John Martin Vorys (R-OH) asserted that India was a “neutral that isn’t even neutral.” Representatives Ralph E. Church (R-IL) and Walter Judd (R-MN) commented that continued assistance to an unsupportive India adversely affected the US position with supportive partners in Asia.